

The Second Aristotle Turns Astro-Lettrist: Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā's *Spellcasters' Treasures* as Early Modern Mongol Grimoire Bestseller

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Only the Mongol Great Weirding could marry Ibn Sīnā, the Second Aristotle, to Ibn 'Arabī, the Second Plato, to imprimatur an old-new Pythagorean science of Persianate empire and technology of time itself: *astro-lettrism*.

Old, since astrology endured as humanity's favorite state science from Sumerian-Babylonian and Egyptian antiquity to Afro-Eurasian and Mesoamerican early modernity, with major reflorescences today; and Arabic lettrism and Hebrew kabbalah together became the preferred vehicle for ancient Pythagorean *mathesis* across the Greater Western world from the thirteenth century onward—a cultural seachange upon which the twentieth-century story (spell) of the “Scientific Revolution” and our own New Mongol Transhumanist Starstraining Algorithmic moment pivot. And so also new: never before, in any known human culture, were stars and alphanumeric letters so definitively imperially married as they came to be in Mongol and post-Mongol Iran under the combined Avicennan-Akbarian aegis.

An epochal philosophical-technological marriage of Aristotelian physics and Platonic metaphysics via a Persianized Pythagoras, astro-lettrism (*'ilm-i nujūm u ḥurūf*)¹ would do much to define the great early modern Persianate imperial cultures down to the colonial era. This old-new innovation is especially associated with the early Timurid period and the New Brethren of Purity, who first formalized this hybrid science for historiographical and political but also technological and indeed military purposes. Thence it served as perennial model for the Mughal (Indo-Timurid), Safavid and Ottoman Empires and smaller states alike, inspiring everything

¹ This dual science name is not formally recorded in Arabo-Persian encyclopedias of the sciences, though represents an epochal and otherwise quite explicit historical phenomenon. My model here is the handle *ahl-i nujūm u tanāsukh*, “starworshippers and reincarnationists,” used in a similarly Pythagorean sense for the Mughal imperial elite under Akbar; see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 170 n. 150.

from cosmology, poetry, architecture and armor to observational astronomy, music, mind-control magic and predictive computing—a sweeping cultural florescence I call the Occult-Scientific Revolution.²

But it is the destructive-creative chaos of the Mongol Marriage of East and West (Afro-Eurasia) that became the alembic in which that Revolution was distilled. Key ingredients of its mash: the western jazz-scientific stylings of the Supreme Master Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 1240) and the Supreme Mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 1225-33), both proto-astro-lettrists; the earlier eastern Pythagoreanizing encyclopedism of the Brethren of Purity, which inspired Arabic grimoires like the tenth- or eleventh-century western *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*, whence the *Picatrix*, its imperfectly translated, ideologically censored Latin-European bestseller) and Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī’s (d. 1210) eastern *Hidden Secret* (*al-Sirr al-maktūm*)—both predicated on the classic Hermetic-theurgic principle of astral-magical Ascent, though not yet astro-lettrist; and *The Comprehensive Book for Making the Complete and Perfected Human* (*Kitāb al-Shāmil wa-baḥr al-kāmil*) of Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī (d. 1229), infamous shaman-grammarian to the Mongols, which likewise prefigured the east-west boom in the *grimoire-as-cosmic-grammar* genre. Cocted through Tenggerid *Skyworship* and the Ṭūsian marriage of observational astronomy-astrology and geomancy to *language-as-magic*, this starword mash further distilled naturally produced the pure spirit of Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā as the world’s first imperial astro-lettrist.³



Only such a distillation process can explain the surprisingly early provenance of *Spellcasters’ Treasures* (*Kunūz al-mu‘azzimīn*), a short, incomplete, Persian grimoire wildly implausibly yet consistently attributed to the Second Aristotle. The fact that it first appears in the *Treasury of Tabriz* (*Safīna-yi Tabrīz*, mostly copied 1321-1323)—now celebrated if eclectic Mongol-imperial encyclopedic curriculum for the universal human, which marries astronomy-astrology to geomancy and other occult sciences under Ṭūsī’s (d. 1274) aegis—makes this weirdly hybrid, shapeshifting text a unique window onto that transformative age.⁴ And those that followed: unlike the various Pseudo-Avicennan occult-scientific manuals and attributed operations that pro-

² This introduction synthesizes and summarizes my findings in various studies, the most salient of which are listed in the bibliography. On the late antique foundations of astro-lettrism see Acevedo, *Alphanumeric Cosmology*; on the Mongol grimoiric moment just before its emergence see Noble, *Philosophising the Occult*; Selove and Humble, eds., *A Sorcerer’s Handbook*.

³ The New Testament’s Book of Revelation, many of whose visionary, apocalypticist passages are overtly astrological, also inaugurates the 666 (or 616) Antichrist alphanumericist trope peculiar to the late ancient Mediterranean zone—but for anti-Roman-imperial purposes.

⁴ In her pioneering 2007 study of the *Kunūz* (“La représentativité des matériaux scientifiques,” 214), Vesel proposes a possible dating to the early twelfth century. While its summary appearance in the early fourteenth-century *Safīna-yi Tabrīz* does indicate an earlier origin, I suggest the late thirteenth century as more likely, given our pseudopigraph’s unprecedentedly astro-lettrist nature vis-à-vis contemporary occult-scientific developments, especially as spearheaded by Ṭūsī. See also Tourkin, “Astronomical and Astrological Works”; Qurbān-nizhād, “Risāla-hā-yi awfāq u raml’

liferated in the post-Mongol period, this is the only one that became a runaway bestseller across the early modern Persian cosmopolis—because the perfectly neoclassically iconic model for its Platonic-Pythagorean imperial-algorithmic astro-lettrist culture. It persists in bazaar editions even now, especially online (another imperial-algorithmic irony).⁵

In textual-historical terms, *Spellcasters' Treasures* captures, with admirable economy, the transition from the Akbarian-Būnian jazzy cosmogonic-theurgic proto-astro-lettrism of the early thirteenth century to the systematic and pragmatic (though equally theurgic) techno-astro-lettrism of the late fourteenth and after.⁶ The latter is emblemized by such new classics as ‘Abd Allāh al-Yāfi‘ī’s (d. 1367) *Strung Pearl* (*al-Durr al-naẓīm*) and Muḥammad al-Kūmī al-Tūnisi’s (d. 1407) *Easing Aims* (*Taysīr al-maṭālib*). Yemeni-Hijazi and Maghribi respectively, both with a wide early modern Afro-Eurasian readership, they served to canonize and mainstream this new “techno-Sufism” for Sunni and Shi‘i alike.⁷ But these western, Arabic sources are not explicitly imperialist, and so do not reflect the advent of World-Conqueror Temūr as Chinggis Khan’s Muslim heir and Persianate answer to Alexander as model of Islamic saint-philosopher-kingship.

Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā’s Persian *Treasures* is thus the missing link between such pre-Mongol Pseudo-Aristotelian Arabic classics as *Alexandar’s Treasure* (*Dhakhūrat Iskandar*)—occult-imperialist but not lettrist—and the lettrist-imperialist New Alexandrian turn codified as imperial astro-lettrism under Mongol-Timurid auspices and definitively Pythagoreanized.⁸ Emblematic of this evolution is the reformulation of the late antique ‘Alid-Fāṭimid *Comprehensive Prognosticon* (*al-jafr al-jāmi‘a*) in astro-lettrist terms as celestial-terrestrial, theurgic-imperial Computer for ruling the world by knowing all; the arduous production of such Panopticons—including in handheld, campaign-ready format—became a growth industry across the early modern Persian cosmopolis. (Though serving the same Panopticonic impulse, today’s AIs are violently hostile to astrology—yet their overlords are as obsessed with transhumanist Ascent to the planetary spheres as ever were the ancients.)

The precociousness of our *Kunūz* is likewise traceable through the encyclopedia of the sciences (*taṣnīf al-‘ulūm*) genre, whose Arabic vs. Persian drift from the Mongol era onward—at least with respect to the occult sciences—is historiographically instructive. (The far more dramatic Latin vs. Arabic drift is equally so.) Thus philosopher Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī’s (d. 1209) seminal Persian *Sittīnī* encyclopedia became the first in the whole of the known Greater Western tradi-

⁵ Most appear to be based on Jalāl al-Dīn Humā‘ī’s 1952 critical edition, which identifies a longer and a shorter version, though with many minor variations; I translate the longer version below.

⁶ Earlier efforts in this specifically imperial astro-lettrist direction are exemplified by Fatimid Isma‘ili experimentation, however eclectic and unsystematic, and not particularly Pseudo-Aristotelian; see Matthews, *The Occult Imam*. On the brilliant framing of lettrism as cosmic jazz see Uy, *Lost in a Sea of Letters*.

⁷ That Yāfi‘ī was the master of Shaykh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī (d. 1431)—eponym of the Ni‘matullāhī order, thoroughgoing Akbarian lettrist and Ibn Turka’s friend—is more historical cartilage.

⁸ See Raggetti, “Alchemical Waters.” Its surviving copies in Iran date to the Safavid and Qajar periods, with Persian translations being just as popular as the Arabic variations. Most notably for our purposes here, a nineteenth-century copy is attributed to Shaykh Bahā‘ī himself: Qom, Markaz-i lḥyā’, MS 2126/5, pp. 131-231.

tion to reclassify astrology as a mathematical science, on the eve of the Mongol conquest—but knows nothing of lettrism (*‘ilm-i ḥurūf*); after the conquest, professor Shams al-Dīn Āmulī’s (d. 1352) equally seminal Persian *Jewels of the Sciences* elevates lettrism to the primary technology of Sufism as ultimate cosmopolitical discipline—but demotes astrology (*‘ilm-i nujūm*) back down to a mere natural science. Not expressly Sufi, faithfully Aristotelian, yet mathematizing in a Pythagorean mode, the *Kunūz* both embodies and resolves this encyclopedic tension by pragmatically presuming both planets and alphanumeric letters to be mathematical constructs and hence naturally marriageable.

It is this starletter marriage that made *Spellcasters’ Treasures* the most successful of all Avicennan occult-scientific pseudepigrapha in early modern neoclassicizing hindsight. Unlike Hermetic Pseudo-Aristotle, Hermetic Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā does not otherwise feature as a preeminent occult-technologist of empire in the extant archive. Various treatises on natural magic, alchemy, astrology, oneiromancy, talismanry and magic squares attributed to the Second Aristotle do survive, against all colonialist-Orientalist odds (though for the same reason all remain unedited and unstudied); but most date to well after the fourteenth century, and none became a best-seller—with this one exception that would seem to prove the magico-imperial rule.⁹ The *Kunūz* boasts almost 50 known manuscript copies in Iran alone, mostly from the Safavid and Qajar periods but based on Ilkhanid and Timurid witnesses, testifying to an elite Persianate audience in the many tens of thousands over several centuries, from the eastern Mediterranean to Southeast Asia.¹⁰ This does not include such Avicennan pseudepigrapha as the Arabic *R. Nīranjāt*, whose eighteenth-century Persian translation is clearly a variation on the *Kunūz*;¹¹ an Ottoman Turkish expansion (probably eighteenth-century too) attributed to the First Aristotle instead;¹² or its twentieth-century bazaar edition—now available online and so with an audience in the many millions—which sets the stage (think illusionism as a real science) for the modern, democratizing turn toward the pulp-occult and teach-yourself-magic embodied, for example, by American New Thought.¹³

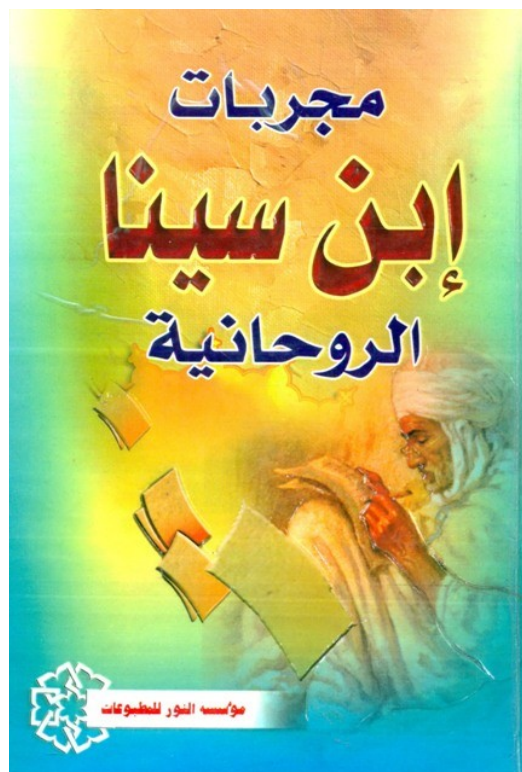
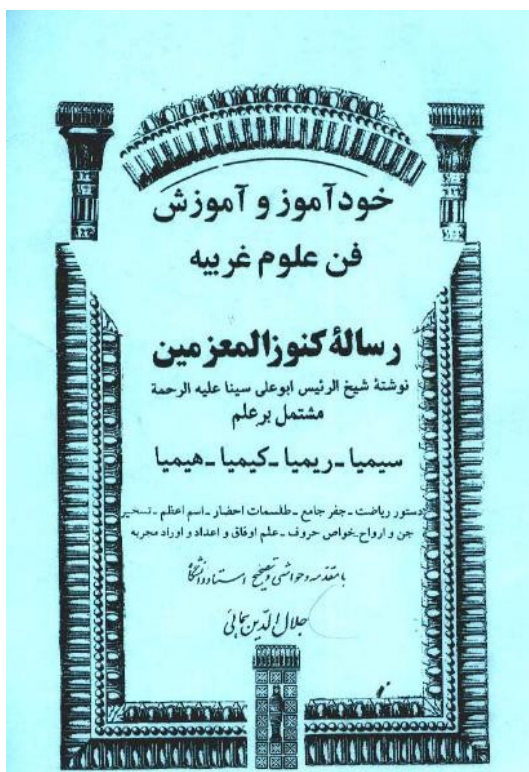
⁹ See Gutas, *Avicenna*, 459, 494, 526; idem, “Avicenna and After.” A purely talismanic Arabic *Mujarrabāt Ibn Sīnā al-rūḥāniyya* would seem to be doing well in the market as well (see Plate 2 below). Cf. Corbin, *Avicenne et le récit visionnaire*.

¹⁰ Beyond Iran, some survive under the obviously mistranscribed title *Kunūz al-mughrimīn fī asrār al-ḥurūf* (following Ullmann, *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften*, 365), including at least one early Timurid copy: Princeton, Garrett Collection, MS 4415Y, f. 17a-29a.

¹¹ Qom, Mar‘ashī Library, MS 14322/7 (Dirāyatī, *FaNKha*, 34:30).

¹² Princeton, Third Series, MS 797, 1b-67a—a miscellany that includes two other lettrist works. See Humā’ī’s introduction for other receptions and technical definitions.

¹³ On the contemporary context see Doostdar, *The Iranian Metaphysicals*.



Plates 1 and 2: Undated twentieth-century bazaar copy of the *Kunūz* in Humā'ī's 1952 edition; the equally pseudepigraphical *Mujarrabāt* (Beirut, 2005)

In today's bazaar grimoire economy, Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā thus stands mythically next to such Safavid imperial Enlightenment philosophers as Mīr Dāmād (d. 1631) and Shaykh Bahā'ī (d. 1621) as actual masters of astro-lettrist science, whose epigraphic and pseudepigraphic works have dominated Iranian scholarly and popular practitioner cultures from the seventeenth century to the present.¹⁴ But here again it is the long Timurid century that provides the textual cartilage to articulate all such post-Mongol Persianate connections and developments; and it is under such Safavid and then Qajar auspices that the *Kunūz* boomed.

Avid customers will note the Occult Quintet (*khamṣa-yi muḥtajiba*) advertisement on the iconic blue cover of this bootlegged version of Jalāl al-Dīn Humā'ī's 1952 critical edition of the *Treasures*. So called after the esotericist code phrase *kullu-hu sirr* (KLHSR), "the whole is a secret," comprising alchemy (*kīmīyā*), talismanry (*līmīyā*), subjugation (*hīmīyā*), illusionism (*sīmīyā*) and conjuring (*rīmīyā*), this modern line of ad magic is a Safavid-Qajar dead giveaway.¹⁵ Riffing on both the Pseudo-Aristotelian-Alexandrian *Secret of Secrets* (*Sirr al-asrār*) and the equally 'Abbasid *Epistles* (*Rasā'il*) of the Brethren of Purity, this *five-occult-sciences-of-empire*

¹⁴ Ghazālī (d. 1111) too became an important lettrist authority for Safavid, Mughal and Ottoman scholars through the same pseudepigraphical process, though not as a standalone bestselling author.

¹⁵ Melvin-Koushki, "The Occult Court," 4. On the above pulp-occult cover, talismanry is oddly dropped from the Quintet, but added again in the subtitle.

trope was first canonized in the high Safavid expansion of *Qasimian Secrets* (*Asrār-i Qāsimī*), the bestselling late Timurid neoclassicist Persian grimoire of Ḥusayn Kāshifī (d. 1505), Herati preacher, Naqshbandi Sufi and early modern Everyman's Librarian—especially with respect to both astrology and lettrism. His son 'Alī Ṣafī (d. 1533) bridged the Timurid-Safavid, Sunni-Shi'i, Arabic-Persian divide with similar grimoiric aplomb: his decrypted summary of the *Secrets* for Qizilbash warlord purposes helped place it at the center of high Safavid imperial discourse and military practice; and his *Amulet of Protection Against the Trials of Time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*)—even more bestselling—epitomizes the new astro-lettrism in an imperial mode. At the same time, its advocacy of what might be called *occult bureaucracy*—whereby it is the technological duty of state functionaries to mind-control kings and warlords through ritual astro-lettrist magic—would seem to be unprecedented in the Greater Western tradition, marking another major transition in the mechanics of empire.

So it is that the early seventeenth-century Safavid expansion of the *Qasimian Secrets* by Jalāl al-Dīn Munajjim Yazdī (d. 1619), chief court astrologer, geomancer and historian to Shah 'Abbās, fuses Ibn Sīnā with Shaykh Bahā'ī on the theme of *taskhīr-i qulūb* in imperial-bureaucratic astro-lettrist fashion:

If one wishes to bend the hearts of kings, sultans and rulers to one's will, such that they will not be able to contradict anything one says or bear one's absence even for a moment, and such that one rises in rank above all one's peers and is held in the highest esteem by sultans, one should, when the Sun is in exaltation, engrave the following number as a 6 x 6 magic square on a plate of gold, and *bismi Llāh bismi Llāh bismi Llāhi l-Raḥmāni l-Raḥīm* [= 1,122] at the top: 3,851.

This operation is one that Shaykh Bū 'Alī [i.e., Ibn Sīnā] took from Shaykh Yaḥyā 'Arab, a prominent scholar of his day, whence Mawlānā Aḥmad Lārī took it. One day this great seal talisman (*muhr*) was described to the king, [which prompted] someone present to remark that Mullā Aḥmad Lārī's books were in the possession of Allāhvirdi Khan. Someone was therefore dispatched to bring these books, and when they had arrived Shaykh Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad [al-'Āmilī] (God sanctify his secret) carried out [on their basis] just this operation to subjugate the hearts of all creatures and kings. He did so in the year 1010 after the Hijra [i.e., 1601] when the Sun was in exaltation, and bound [the resulting seal talisman] on the arm of the king. The first conquest [Shah 'Abbās] achieved [as a result] was his taking of Tabriz [from the Ottomans in 1603]; thenceforth his career of conquest (*jahāngīrī*) was daily furthered. [A similar seal talisman] was made for the renowned governor (*navvāb-i 'aliyya-yi 'āliya*) [Allāhvirdi Khan], who attained his exalted office thereby. There is, in short, no better operation than this for the purpose of subjugation.¹⁶

¹⁶ Pseudo-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, 88-89; on this expansion and its context see Subtelny, "Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*" Allāhvirdi Khan (d. 1613), a Georgian military slave, became the most powerful of non-Qizilbash amirs in service to Shah 'Abbās, who appointed him governor of Fars and effectively second-in-command (Savory, s.v., *Elr*).

By the same Safavid token, Abū l-Qāsm Anṣārī Kāzīrūnī (b. 1559), prominent Shirazi scholar under Shah ‘Abbās I and student of Ibn Turka’s great-great-grandson Afzal al-Dīn b. Ḥabīb Allāh Turka (d. 1583), is full-on Pythagoreanizing in his eclectic, genre-bending *Sullam al-samāwāt*, “equal parts theological tract, history of philosophy, literary history and encyclopedia of the sciences.”¹⁷ Epitomizing the Persianate imperial occult-scientific universalist ethos, *Ladder to the Heavens*—the title is Platonically, Hermetically, theurgically literal—not only names the *Kunūz* as Ibn Sīnā’s most famous authentic work on the occult sciences, but goes further in the same Pythagorean vein to make the Second Aristotle the OG Platonic Theurgist. According to him and all his Peripatetic disciples:

The spheres’ motions are volitional, and the spheres and their planets entirely conscious. Thus they hold there to be an incalculable host of spirits and souls inhabiting each sphere—some of which spirits are explicitly named in the works of the ancients.¹⁸

Here their *naming* is key. It is the obviously pseudepigraphical *Treasures* that first shows the way to the formal, less jazzy talismanic harnessing of Stars through Letters by way of Names, which Algorithm became all the imperial-bureaucratic Persianate vogue from the Mongol era onward—thanks not least to its *Treasury of Tabriz* scientific debut.



The early modern manuscript record tells the same Safavid Avicennan astro-lettrist story. Among the most telling of many *majmū‘as* are two. Copied in 1130/1718, Majlis MS 1178 marries the *Treasures* not only to Shaykh Bahā’ī, but also to the latter’s teacher in astro-lettrism, Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576), the most prolific Persian author on that dual science of the sixteenth century and self-identified New Brother, who Twelverized it definitively, as the Safavid *Qasimian Secrets* attests.¹⁹ Likewise the eighteenth-century Majlis MS 14910, which organically associates Shaykh Bahā’ī with the *Treasures* and both with Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 1502) on the same theme—Davānī being a firmly Sunni Ash‘ari philosopher and Aqquyunlu operative but also an Enlightenment astro-lettrist in the Timurid-Ibn Turkian mode.

These two plates from the latter miscellany give a visual taste of the elite scientific ethos in which Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā was (and is) enduringly read, sometimes with enthusiastic marginal commentary:

¹⁷ Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 164.

¹⁸ Kāzīrūnī, *Sullam al-samāwāt*, p. 184-187 (entry on Ibn Sīnā), esp. p. 185.

¹⁹ Tehran, Majlis Library, MS 1178/48, pp. 677-83, copied 1130/1718. See Melvin-Koushki, “Pseudo-Shaykh Bahā’ī”; idem, “Occult Ecumenism.”

—and propose the *Kunūz* as a crucial missing link.²⁰ The Mongol-Timurid advent of *astro-lettrism* that this bestseller epitomizes likewise allows us to remarry Religion to Science, Technology and Empire through the good offices of Magic.

By the same token, the mere existence of this curiously dual-scientific text should prompt specialists in the Pseudo-Aristotelian Hermetica to expand their purview beyond pre-Mongol, “classical” Arabic texts, fragments and passing references, in which context they have almost exclusively been studied, with necessarily ambiguous results.²¹ The almost total neglect—bizarrely antiphilological—of the much greater wealth of post-Mongol New Persian texts in the same Hellenistic vein is due in the first place to the persistent classicocentrist genetics of our field, spawn of the European Renaissance fiction and then modern colonial fact of Islam as Not-West, as alien detour from Pure Greekness, whose classical and hence eternal enemy is of course Per- sianness. Under such sorcerous storytelling conditions, the perennial fact of historical change and new human cultural syntheses and marriages of opposites becomes unimaginable; this magical snakepit is courtesy of modernity’s “Enlightened” abandonment of the venerable *munāẓara* tradition, wherein debates were ideally resolved by Emperor Love as ultimate cosmic principle (aka Pythagorean-Newtonian gravitation), which makes all civilization possible.²²

As it philologically turns out, Latinate parochialism aside, “post-classical” Persian and Greek did in fact become lovers—especially in matters occult-scientific. And so it is that the Hermetic (read: Occult) First *and* Second Aristotle occur in the surviving archive more often in New Persian than in Arabic (and in both far more often than in Latin and Greek) by a good two orders of magnitude. This is thanks to the military and economic hegemony of post-Mongol Persianate empires, whose astro-lettrist proclivities saw the Arabo-Persian grimoire industry boom across the Afro-Eurasian ecumene, with increasing production in Ottoman Turkish as chief Persianate vernacular and then (by the nineteenth century) Urdu as well. The same boom did much to make the Indian Ocean as central early modern imperial arena an Enchanted Islamic Sea.²³

Nor does the blatantly pseudepigraphical yet bestselling nature of this astro-lettrist text just speak to a premodern transitional moment, but to our own Algorithmic one too, when AI—curiously lettrist yet ensloppifying hex—is consuming physical oceans to produce digital oceans of deranging pseudepigrapha, in which all human knowing must drown. Under such neo-impe-

²⁰ Lory, *La science des lettres en Islam* (2004); idem, “Kashifi’s *Asrār-i Qāsimī*” (2003).

²¹ Thus van Bladel, *The Arabic Hermes*. Any assumption as to the existence of a coherent “Islamic Hermeticism” is merely an academic projection from the Renaissance Latinate, and hence Eurocentric by definition; in the post-Mongol Persianate imperial context, Plato, Aristotle and Pythagoras feature far more often than Hermes even on matters Hermetic, with Mercury but the higher octave of the Moon. But by the same Eurocentric token, thanks to Yates, “Hermetic” hits in Modern English as “occult-scientific.” The *Kunūz* can therefore be read as a Pseudo-Aristotelian Hermetic neoclassic—with a fresh Pythagoreanizing kick.

²² Ibn Turka (d. 1432) in particular was responsible for reformulating this literary genre *lettrarily* in philosophical, sociopolitical, scientific and technological terms, setting the post-Mongol Persianate precedent; see Melvin-Koushki, “Imperial Talismanic Love.”

²³ AlMaazmi, “An Enchanted Sea.”

rially sorcerous storytelling circumstances, *Spellcasters' Treasures* makes all the more sense as not merely a Mongol neoclassical grimoire title, but a wonderfully instructively adaptive model for navigating and surviving Great Weirdings, whether past, present or future, when occult science strains anew for the stars.



Note on the translation: Professor Jalāl al-Dīn Humāʾī's (d. 1980) 1952 edition orders the variations in his six manuscripts into two main versions, a longer and a shorter, the first based on a Sipahsālār *majmūʿa* copy he dates to the fourteenth or fifteenth century, whose first part features seven *faṣls* (some later copies have more) and the beginning of a part two on talismanic rings. He is unaware of its presence in the *Treasury of Tabriz* (Tehran, Majlis Library, MS 14590/78, p. 344), since that wonderfully eclectic, pro-occult-science compendium only came to scholarly attention over two decades after his death.²⁴ But its version of the *Kunūz* corresponds to Humāʾī's second, shorter version, which reads as an executive summary; it lacks the operative detail of version one that makes this Pseudo-Avicennan grimoire the first, to my knowledge, to be systematically astro-lettrist.

I therefore translate only that fuller version below as the better window onto the Occult-Scientific Revolution during its Mongol inception. As mirror to that moment, it too is tantalizingly incomplete, even in its later receptions—yet helped provide a template for the reinvention of talismanry in strictly astro-lettrist and theurgic terms from the early Timurid era onward. This feature alone explains the frequent pairing of the *Kunūz* with both astronomical works and astrological and lettrist ones in early modern miscellanies, preserving for posterity a specifically Ṭūsian vibe.

Readers will likewise note the explicitly experimentalist (*tajribī*) tenor of the opening Egyptian anecdote, which strikes a classic Pseudo-Aristotelian Hermetic tone; even more classic are the talismanic applications of planet-letter marriages, here almost exclusively political. (Kāzīrūnī attests his successful personal experimentation with a number of the techniques in the *Kunūz* and other Pseudo-Avicennan occult-scientific works.²⁵) More innovatively, by contrast, *Spellcasters' Treasures* takes *taksīr* for granted as a primary lettrist technique in talisman creation for splicing human and planet names together, but adds short vowels as elementally equally important in any human-planet marriage invocation—shades of Timurid developments onward.²⁶ Such are the textual, technological and political transformations that make Professor Lory's philological marriage of pre-Mongol Ibn ʿArabī and Būnī to post-Mongol Kāshifī all the more prescient.

²⁴ Seyed-Gohrab and McGlinn, eds., *The Treasury of Tabriz*.

²⁵ Kāzīrūnī, *Sullam al-samāwāt*, p. 187.

²⁶ To my knowledge, Ibn Turka is the first in the Greater Western tradition to provide a systematic lettrist theory behind such talismanic vowelings; see his *R. dar Maʿnī-yi khavāṣṣ-i ʿilm-i šarf*, ed. and trans. in Melvin-Koushki, *Persian Pythagoreanism*.



Spellcasters' Treasures

Pseudo-Ibn Sīnā

In the name of God, All-Merciful, Ever-Merciful

God Most High by virtue of His Wisdom and by dint of His Power created the world as it should be created, manifesting a new thing out of nothing, then chose us from among all things and endowed us with seeing hearts and speaking tongues and these faces of such beauty, then showed us the paths to paradise and to hell and sent the Prophet with a message charged—God Most High's blessings be upon all prophets, and especially the best of creation and chosen one of the All-Merciful and Seal of the prophets, Lord of the Tablet and the Pen and Burāq and Ascent, Glory of Sacred and Secular and Throne and Crown, Master and Epitome of all beings, Muḥammad the Chosen One, God bless and keep him!

To proceed: Says the author of the present work and composer of these lines, Abū 'Alī Sīnā of Bukhara (God's mercy be upon him), King of Philosophers and Chief of Scholars: A group of friends and companions begged me repeatedly and vigorously to write a summary book for their edification; since they were well within their rights in making this demand, I acceded and composed this work for them. Titled *Spellcasters' Treasures*, it consists of two main sections. It must be hidden from the ignorant and unworthy, and [its operations] not used for illegal ends, on pain of divine judgment—and God alone helps and grants success.

Part One, in seven discourses:

- 1) The letters' elemental natures
- 2) Deriving planetary names
- 3) Planetary suffumigations
- 4) Planetary dress and adornment
- 5) Using *taksīr* to combine your name with planetary names
- 6) Using *taksīr* to determine the purpose to which each planet may be put and the number of invocation repetitions appropriate
- 7) Some love operations [as example]

Part Two: The Form and Active Properties of Talismanic Rings of the Seven Planets and How to Draw Them

[Before proceeding, an introductory] excursus:

Know (God Most High felicitate you) that a specific form of wisdom underlies the existence of every single creature, whether physical or mental, such that each has a unique virtue not fully known to our science. But prophets (blessings and peace upon them) discovered these virtues through their personal enlightenment by way of the celestial spheres, then communicated them to us. It is therefore incumbent upon us to examine [their findings] with the eye of insight and arrange and observe them systematically.

God Most High created this world subject to the sphere of the Moon [specifically] and the 12 signs of the zodiac and seven planets [generally], all of which determine a person's horoscope. It is therefore imperative when performing an operation for someone that you know their birth time so you know the appropriate planet to address, since their luck depends on its being in domicile, exaltation, detriment, fall, direct or retrograde motion or combust, and in a favorable position according to sign and degree, and positively or negatively aspected, as well as other indicators of weakness or strength. If you do not have this data, you may accidentally perform a love operation at a malefic hour or a hate operation at a benefic one: for not every moment is equally appropriate, and [the wrong timing] can easily spoil it.

An anecdote [to illustrate], from a most trustworthy source: "I was in the realm of Egypt when I was seized by a great desire to spend all my time touring the Pyramids and other great edifices. One day while so touring I chanced to come across an arch upon which were carved images in high relief, including one of a sprightly lamb which took my fancy, so I took an impression of it with a piece of wax I had with me. Walking back from that site I was admiring that image—and wherever I passed by sheep would look at me and move in my direction, such that when their shepherds saw this and tried to beat the sheep back, they would not be deterred, till a multitude was following me. Thereupon the shepherds yelled: 'You obviously have a talisman and are working magic!' Shocked by this, I swore: 'I know nothing of that science and am just as astonished as you are! The only thing I know is that I have this piece of wax!' I angrily crushed it, destroying the image—and immediately the sheep returned to their shepherds. [Even more shocked], I later tried to reproduce this procedure several times, but it had no effect."

From this we learn that timing is of the utmost operational importance, and that not all times can be accounted the same. In electing operations clients request great care must therefore be taken to study the matter closely, meet all requirements and follow all indications to quickly achieve the desired result and avoid error.

[Part One:]

Discourse One: The Letters' Elemental Natures

The letters of the [Arabic] alphabet fall into four categories: letters of **Fire**, **Earth**, **Air** and **Water**. Likewise, the accusative case is Fiery, the nominative case Earthy, the genitive case Airy and the jussive case Watery. [The letters' elemental natures] are as follows:

- ◆ Fire letters: **AWYLMN**^c
- ◆ Earth letters: **JZKSFTḤ**
- ◆ Air letters: **HRShThDhṢṬ**
- ◆ Water letters: **BDKhZGhDQ**

Discourse Two: Deriving Planetary Names

Taking the first Fire letter, the first Earth letter, the first Air letter and the first Water letter, we apply them to **Saturn**, whose letters are therefore **AJHB**. Taking the second Fire letter, the second Earth letter, the second Air letter and the second Water letter, we apply them to **Jupiter**, whose letters are therefore **WZRD**. Taking the third letter of each element, we apply them to **Mars**, giving his letters: **YKShKh**. Taking the fourth letter of each, we apply them to the **Sun**, giving his letters: **LSThZ**. Taking the fifth letter of each, we apply them to **Venus**, giving her letters: **MFDhGh**. Taking the sixth letter of each, we apply them to **Mercury**, giving his/her letters: **NTṢD**. And taking the seventh letter of each, we apply them to the **Moon**, giving his letters: **ḤṬQ**. These are the planets' letters according to their elemental natures [in descending cosmic order]; thus writing these four letter series to stand for their associated planets works for any planetary operation at the needful time.

Discourse Three: Planetary Suffumigations

Each planet has a suffumigation peculiar to it, which when used at the needful time will speed the operation's desired effect. These are the incenses of each planet listed with their individual ingredients:

- ◆ **Saturn**: Equal parts tar, lead fragments, alkali and oriental cashew.
- ◆ **Jupiter**: Equal parts camphor, red sandalwood, coral fragments, hard acorn (unpierced) and dry saffron.
- ◆ [**Mars**: [Equal parts] mastic, aloe, opium and pepper.]
- ◆ **Sun**: Equal parts mastic, musk skin, ivory pieces and Armenian bole bound in spurge oil and cooked.
- ◆ **Venus**: Equal parts (by weight) orange skin, saffron and mixed silver and copper pieces bound in rosewater.

- ◆ **Mercury:** Equal parts (by weight) sweet basil leaves, lapis lazuli, ground pepper and orange leaves bound in saffron water.
- ◆ **Moon:** Equal parts sandarac, pounded amber, white ambergris and ladanum bound in myrtle water and cooked.

Burning of the appropriate incense is imperative for the success of any planetary operation.

Discourse Four: Planetary Dress and Adornment

Each planet likewise has a ritual garment peculiar to it, to be worn while observing that planet's transits, together with a ring associated with that planet, as noted. Face the zodiacal sign the planet currently occupies and burn the aforementioned incense when making your request to speed its realization.

- ◆ **Saturn:** At the moment of invocation wear a long blue garment and two rings, one of iron and one of lead, engraving thereon the letters **NT**, then face the sign Saturn is occupying and burn his incense and make your request.
- ◆ **Jupiter:** Acting like a monk or worshiper, wear a yellow and white garment and a cornelian ring engraved with the letters **HJ**, then face Jupiter and burn his incense.
- ◆ **Mars:** Acting like a man of war, wear a green tunic and brandish a drawn sword, wearing an iron ring engraved with the letters **MD** and suffumigated with aloewood, then burn his incense.
- ◆ **Sun:** Acting like a king, wear a fine yellow and red garment and a yellow-[gemmed] ring engraved with an image of the Sun, then burn the Sun's incense in a yellow censer.
- ◆ **Venus:** Acting like a woman, wear a fine purple garment and a crown and every kind of jewel, and a copper ring engraved with the letters **BDh**, then burn the aforementioned incense.
- ◆ **Mercury:** Acting like a secretary, wear a woolen, open-fronted tunic with a sash, then burn the aforementioned incense and make your request.
- ◆ **Moon:** Acting like a messenger, courier or page, wear a perfumed silver garment and a silver ring engraved with an image of the Moon, then burn the Moon's incense and undertake the operation.

If no errors mar one's operation, and auspicious times and hours are scrupulously observed, its objective will be achieved the same hour.

Discourse Five: Using taksir to Combine Your Name with Planetary Names

Should you wish to use *taksir* to combine your name with any of the planets, [follow the same procedure] described above: burn that planet's incense, wear its garments and rings, and make

sure it is not retrograde or in its fall or detriment, or squaring or opposing a malefic planet. These conditions being met, write your name and your mother's name after it, followed by the letters of the planet in question, all three together [in a line] (the planets being reducible to letters). Then take the first letter of each, the second of each, the third of each and the fourth: each name [so derived] that [results in three letters without remainder] is complete, but those with remainder letters must be further derived until complete too, repeating them to that end. All three complete names are then combined and vowelings added to make them pronounceable, per the principle discussed: accusative *a* is Fire, nominative *u* is Earth, genitive *i* is Air and jussive stop is Water.

For example, the name **Ḥusayn**, whose mother is **Fāṭima**, for a **Jupiter (WZRD)** operation gives **ḤSYNFAṬMHWZRD**. Taking the first letter of each of the three names gives **ḤFW**, taking the second gives **SAZ**, taking the third gives **YṬR** and taking the fourth gives **NMD**. Since the name **Ḥusayn** is four letters, it is complete, but the name **Fāṭima**, which is five letters, is not: so take the first letter of **Ḥusayn** and the first letter of **Jupiter** [and combine with the remainder letter of **Fāṭima**, *H*], to give **ḤHW**. Then combining all three and adding appropriate vowelings, we derive from the names **Ḥusayn**, **Fāṭima** and the planet **Jupiter** **ḤaFuWiSAZaYuṬiRNaMuDiḤi-HaWi**.²⁷ (In the vowelings process, if two consecutive stops would otherwise normally occur in Persian, replace one with an *i* to make it pronounceable.)

Proceed in the same way with each planetary operation you wish to perform, with attention to the peculiar requirements of each planet in terms of its [auspicious] hours for burning its incense, its being in good condition with good aspects, wearing its peculiar garments, as discussed above. Also as discussed, only then should you combine your name with that of your target planet, invoking it according to the number specified through derivation therefrom and only when in the correct zodiacal sign, then raising your hands and calling out your request.

The number of invocations peculiar to each planet will be discussed below, as will the requests appropriate; but [generally] *taksīr* must be used when specifying one's objective and determining the number of invocations necessary.

NB: If you know your horoscope's ruling planet, it is better [to use it instead of your mother's name]: rather combine your name with the letters of that planet with the letters of the planet you wish to work with, following the **Ḥusayn-Fāṭima-Jupiter** model above, and burn the incenses of both planets and invoke them both. But before doing so it must be emphasized that the two planets must have at least a slightly friendly relationship; if they are enemies, however, just use your name with your mother's name and the planet's.

Discourse Six: The Purposes to Which Each Planet May Be Put and Its Required Number of Invocations

²⁷ This applies the accusative, nominative, genitive and jussive order, as specified in the text, though left unvoiced in the edition.

- ◆ **Saturn:** Invoke seven times to conquer fortresses, rescue old family members, seize property and vanquish an enemy army.
- ◆ **Jupiter:** Invoke six times to empower Islam, spread Law, manifest justice and perpetuate faith in peace, and to be held mighty and powerful by the populace.
- ◆ **Mars:** Invoke five times to overpower and destroy enemies and empower your army.
- ◆ **Sun:** Invoke four times to perpetuate sultanate, caliphate and kingship; enemies who attack will be vanquished, and all who are subjected will be subjected easily.
- ◆ **Venus:** Invoke three times for luxury, pleasure, fortune and delight and the love and admiration of all (especially women), and perpetual joy and happiness.
- ◆ **Mercury:** Invoke two times to increase savings and stores and gain great wealth and property.
- ◆ **Moon:** Invoke one time to counter magic, deceit, sorcery and treachery, or for bodily health and vitality, and so on.

These numbers are simply according to the order of the planets: Saturn in the seventh heaven is invoked seven times, Jupiter in the sixth six times, down to the Moon in the first invoked once. Some philosophers, however, maintain that every planet must be invoked seven times, others 33 times; but all three prescriptions are correct.

Discourse Seven: Some Love Operations

If you wish to subjugate someone to your will (*taskhīr*), you must learn which planet rules their horoscope and make sure it is not retrograde or in its fall or detriment and free of bad aspects and in good condition, as discussed; then burn the appropriate incense in their planet's hour, observing its transits, and wear its garments and rings; then write the client's name, the target's name and the planetary name and combine these three using *taksīr* to give the necessary letters.

For example, write the names **Muḥammad** and **Fāṭima** with that of the planet **Venus**, **MFD-hGh**, where Muḥammad (**MḤMD**) is the client and Fāṭima (**FĀTMH**) his desired. We take in order the first letter of each, the second, the third and fourth to complete each name, as discussed, and again for other names [with more than four letters, here Fāṭima], giving for these three names **MaFuMiḤAFaMuṬiDhDaMuGhiMHaM**.²⁸ (Again, we replace the second of two stops with an *i* [to enable its pronunciation].)

When you have derived these letters from this combination of your name and that of your target and their planetary ruler, having determined a good time and observed all conditions, write them on four pieces of paper and suffumigate these, then make four forms of pure wax and insert into the middle of each a pinch of the planetarily appropriate incense with one of the inscribed pieces of paper, then recite these letters over each form 33 times. Cast the first into fire, bury the second in clean dirt untouched by any foot, throw the third into the air at a perpetually windy place and the fourth into pure water, ideally running—and the target will come and

²⁸ Per Humāṭī's introduction, later manuscripts have other vowelings (p. 18 n. 4).

submit themselves to you within the hour and do whatever you command. But any error or failure to observe the correct planetary times will result in the failure of the operation, and the target will not come.

Another operation: Observing the same conditions, write these letters on four pieces of paper, but instead write them with [ink of] musk and saffron while burning the same incenses, then place them on a dry brick heated red-hot with the incenses on top until they burn while reciting these letters 33 times—and your objective will be realized within the hour.

Part Two: The Form and Active Properties of Talismanic Rings of the Seven Planets and How to Draw Them

This is a science most noble and elite: any who would use it must learn it fully and never for sport, and be pure in both body and intention, with a heart cleaving to God, to ensure the efficacy of the operation. If these conditions are not strictly met, not only will it not work, but may cause injury [to the operator] too.

It is essential to identify which planet is associated with the desired objective and can best facilitate it, observing the conditions discussed above. [But here] the planet must be in ideal condition, the stronger and more auspiciously aspected the better. Care must likewise be taken to ensure that it is not retrograde, in its fall or detriment or combust, or squaring or opposing Mars, all of which are counter-indicated. And when making a talismanic ring, as discussed, the planet's associated incense must be burned and its transits strictly observed.

- ◆ **Saturn:** On a Saturday, when the Moon is in either Capricorn or Aquarius and aspecting Saturn, make a lead ring with a Saturnian stone and engrave it with the image of a man standing with the Moon in his grasp and stepping on a green serpent

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